

5 Essential Puerto Rican Recipes

Sofrito · Arroz con Pollo · Pernil · Tostones · Flan

Bilingual · Mainland-tested · From the Ortiz kitchen

Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

How to use this kit

Batch the sofrito first — one batch is a month of flavor in the freezer. Then cook your first dish: arroz con pollo. Every recipe uses ingredients you can find on the mainland, with swaps where it counts.

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Homemade Sofrito

La base de todo · The base of everything · The essential Puerto Rican flavor base — a fragrant green blend of recaio, garlic, onion, bell pepper, and cilantro.

Ingredients

- 1 bunch recaio (cilantro), about 15 leaves
- 1 large green bell pepper, seeded and chopped
- 1 medium onion, quartered
- 8 cloves garlic, peeled
- 1/2 cup cilantro (fresh coriander), with stems
- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 1 teaspoon salt

Steps

1. Wash all herbs and vegetables thoroughly.
2. Add recaio, bell pepper, onion, garlic, and cilantro to a food processor.
3. Pulse until finely chopped but not pureed — you want texture.
4. Add olive oil and salt. Pulse 3-4 more times to combine.
5. Transfer to ice cube trays or jars. Freeze in portions for up to 3 months.

Arroz con Pollo

El clásico de una olla · The one-pot classic · Puerto Rico's classic one-pot chicken and rice — deeply flavored with sofrito, sazón, olives, and peas.

Ingredients

- 2 lbs chicken pieces
- 2 cups rice
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 cup tomato sauce
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup olives
- 1/2 cup peas
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt and pepper to taste

Steps

1. Season chicken pieces with salt and pepper. Brown in oil over medium-high heat, about 4 minutes per side. Remove and set aside.
2. In the same pot, sauté the sofrito for 2 minutes. Add sazón and tomato sauce, stir to combine.
3. Add rice and stir to coat in the sofrito mixture.
4. Pour in chicken broth, add chicken pieces back in along with olives. Bring to a boil.
5. Cover, reduce heat to low, and cook for 25 minutes. Add peas during the last 5 minutes. Fluff and serve.

Pernil Asado

El rey de la Nochebuena · The king of Nochebuena · Slow-roasted Puerto Rican pork shoulder with crispy skin, garlicky mojo criollo, and juicy fall-apart meat.

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder (8-10 lbs)
- 8 cloves garlic, mashed into a paste
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 2 tablespoons dried oregano
- 1 tablespoon black pepper
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 2 tablespoons white vinegar
- 1/4 cup sofrito

Steps

1. Score the pork skin in a crosshatch pattern with a sharp knife, cutting through the fat but not into the meat.
2. Make the mojo criollo: mash garlic with oregano, pepper, salt, vinegar, olive oil, and sofrito into a thick paste.
3. Rub the paste all over the pork, working it under the skin and into every crevice.
4. Cover tightly and refrigerate overnight (at least 8 hours) to let the marinade penetrate.
5. Roast at 375°F for about 4 hours, basting every hour, until the internal temperature reaches 185°F and the skin is crackling-crispy.
6. Let rest for 20 minutes before carving. The juices redistribute and the skin stays crisp.

Tostones

El crujido perfecto · The perfect crunch · Crispy golden twice-fried green plantains — the classic Puerto Rican side dish.

Ingredients

- 4 green plantains
- Vegetable or canola oil for frying
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1/2 cup water
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tablespoon fresh lime juice
- Pinch of black pepper

Steps

1. Peel the green plantains and cut them into 1-inch thick rounds.
2. Heat oil to 325°F and fry plantain pieces for 3-4 minutes until lightly golden. Remove and drain.
3. Make mojo by mixing water, minced garlic, lime juice, salt, and pepper. Soak the fried pieces for 2 minutes.
4. Smash each piece flat using a tostonera or the bottom of a glass to about 1/4-inch thickness.
5. Increase oil temperature to 375°F and fry the smashed pieces for 2-3 minutes until golden and crispy.
6. Drain on paper towels, season with a pinch of salt, and serve immediately with mayo-ketchup.

Flan de Queso

El postre más cremoso · The creamiest dessert · The creamiest Puerto Rican flan — a rich, silky custard with cream cheese and a perfect caramel topping.

Ingredients

- 1 cup granulated sugar (for caramel)
- 5 large eggs
- 1 can (14 oz) sweetened condensed milk
- 1 can (12 oz) evaporated milk
- 8 oz cream cheese, softened
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- 1/4 teaspoon salt

Steps

1. Preheat oven to 350°F. Place a large roasting pan in the oven with 1 inch of hot water for the water bath.
2. Make the caramel: heat sugar in a saucepan over medium heat, stirring occasionally, until melted and deep amber. Pour into a 9-inch round baking dish and swirl to coat the bottom and sides.
3. Blend eggs, condensed milk, evaporated milk, cream cheese, vanilla, and salt until completely smooth — about 2 minutes on high.
4. Strain the mixture through a fine-mesh sieve into the caramel-lined dish to remove any lumps or air bubbles.
5. Place the flan dish in the water bath. Bake for 55-65 minutes until set but still slightly jiggly in the center.
6. Cool completely, then refrigerate for at least 4 hours or overnight. Run a knife around the edge and invert onto a large plate to serve.